

Honeylocust

Gleditsia triacanthos



Origin

Native to the central United States, especially the Mississippi and Ohio river valleys, where it once grew alongside now-extinct giant ground sloths that ate its seed pods.

Look for

Almost all street honeylocusts are thornless cultivars -- the wild species has vicious branched thorns that once deterred giant Ice Age herbivores from stripping its bark.

IDENTIFICATION TIPS

- Leaf: compound, made of many small oval leaflets along a central stalk.
- Bark/branches: modern street trees are thornless; wild honeylocust has large branched thorns.
- Seed pod: long, flat, and twisted like a corkscrew.
- Commonly confused with: black locust (honeylocust's leaflets are smaller and more numerous, and its pods are longer and more twisted).

THROUGH THE SEASONS

Spring	Tiny compound leaflets emerge late, giving a soft green haze.
Summer	Fine, feathery foliage lets dappled light through.
Fall	Leaves turn clear yellow and drop quickly, all at once.
Winter	Bare, airy branching; old seed pods may still hang on.

DID YOU KNOW

- Its long, twisting seed pods contain a sweet, edible pulp -- the name "honey" locust refers to that pulp, not to bees.
- Because its leaves are so finely divided, honeylocust casts light, dappled shade -- grass and other plants often grow well underneath it.